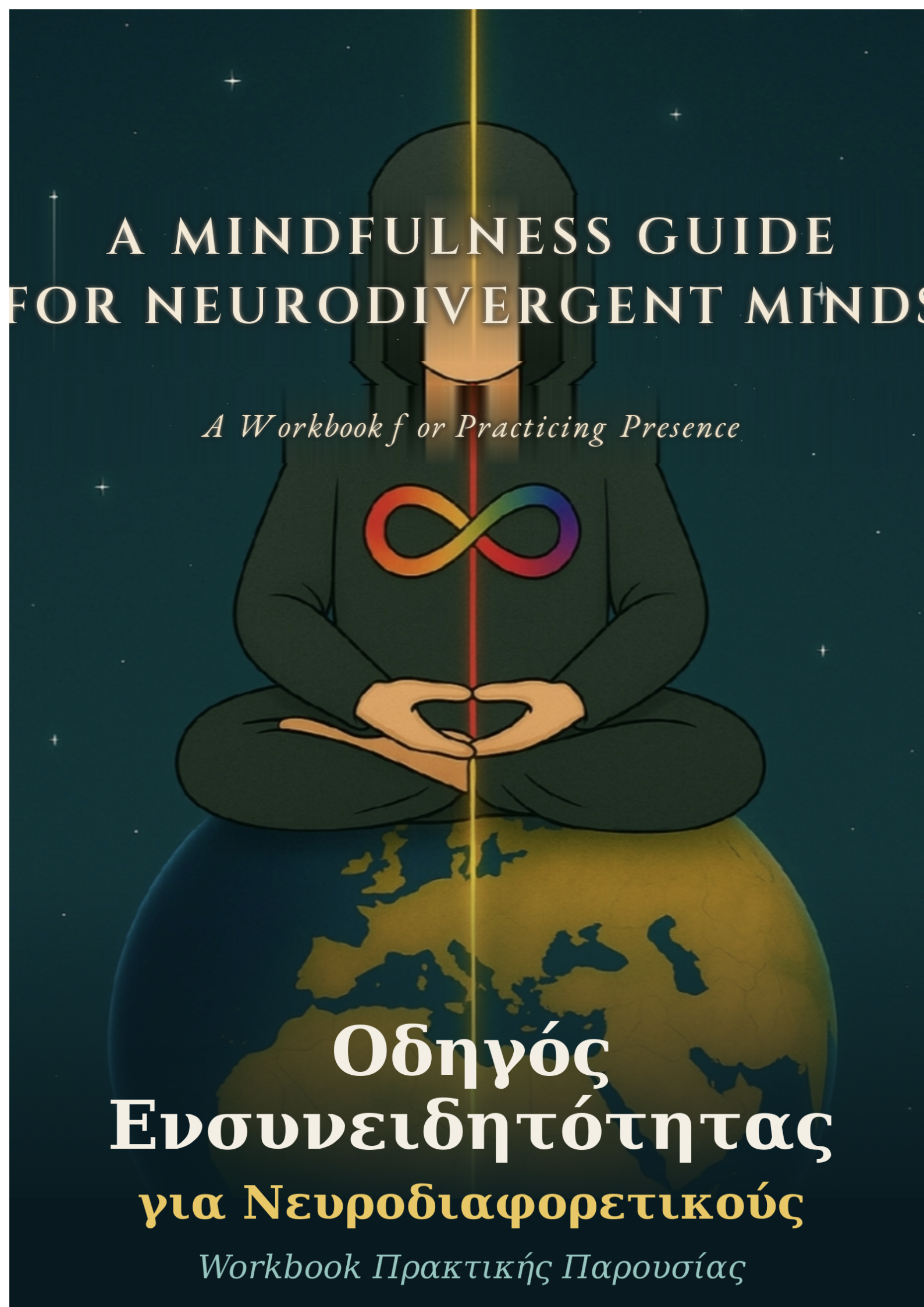




A MINDFULNESS GUIDE FOR NEURODIVERGENT MINDS

A Workbook for Practicing Presence

Οδηγός
Ενσυνειδητότητας
για Νευροδιαφορετικούς

Workbook Πρακτικής Παρουσίας

A Mindfulness Guide for Neurodivergent Minds

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Theodoros Bairaktaris

2025

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A Mindfulness Guide for Neurodivergent Minds

A Workbook for Practicing Presence

Based on the Fourfold Axis: Body · Breath · Attention · Space

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Introduction

Who Is This Book For?

This guide is for anyone who feels disconnected — for those whose mind never stops running, whose body is in constant alert, and for whom calm feels like a foreign language.

It is a tool for people living with the impact of trauma, with neurodivergence (such as ADHD), or simply with the chronic pressure of modern life.

There is nothing in you that needs “fixing,” because nothing is broken. The aim is to learn to return — gently and kindly — to your own living presence.

A Note on the Wisdom of the Body

The mind has no sense of “now.” It travels endlessly between memories of the past and projections of the future.

The body, by contrast — through the undeniable facts of gravity and breath — is always here. For those of us who have felt disconnected, coming back to the present is not merely a psychological exercise; it is an embodied journey of reconnection.

A Personal Note — A Path, Not a Theory

This guide was not born in a laboratory or an academic office. It was born out of personal necessity. When my son was diagnosed with ADHD, I realized that I am neurodivergent too.

What we needed was a method of self-soothing and self-regulation that didn’t require us to “fight” our brains — but to work with them, embracing distraction instead of treating it as an enemy.

“My mind never stopped racing — but it stopped sweeping me away.”

How Do We Define Mindfulness?

Mindfulness is not some mysterious “something” to be attained. It is the natural experience that arises when four main centers of consciousness are working together, at the same time and in harmony.

- **BODY** — The felt sense of inhabiting a body that touches, feels, and connects to the earth through gravity.
- **BREATH** — Awareness of our life rhythm — the continuous flow of inhale and exhale that joins us to the world.

- **ATTENTION** — The capacity to direct the light of our awareness — to focus, to open, or simply to observe.
- **SPACE** — The sense of the open field within and around us, in which thoughts, feelings, and sensations appear and dissolve.

Under stress or in distraction, these centers may operate in isolation — or even in conflict. The method that follows is simple: we make contact with each center on its own, and then tune them so they work in parallel. We are not changing ourselves. We are attuning, and making room for, what is already there.

How to Use This Guide

- The exercises are playful in spirit. There are no mistakes — only experiments.
- Presence doesn't have to last for hours. It begins with wins of a few seconds.
- The instructions are clear, but feel free to adapt them to your own needs.
- Consistency in small doses matters more than duration.

At a few points in the program you'll come across names from contemplative traditions — Dzogchen, Mahamudra, samatha. They appear as the historical sources of the exercises, the way we might credit the researcher behind a study. No belief is required — and none is being suggested. The method rests entirely on observation and on your own experience.

Companion app: Every exercise in this book also exists in interactive, animated form at neurodivergent-mindfulness.org. For audio — binaural beats and calm soundscapes that support regulation — visit the [Sanctuary](#). The app is free, with no account and no tracking.

If, during the exercises, your emotions become overwhelming or cause you real distress, the support of a therapist can make an important difference. Compassion sits at the heart of the practice of presence.

Part 1 — The Core of the Method

The Fourfold Axis: Body · Breath · Attention · Space

The next four chapters introduce the four centers of consciousness at the core of this practice. Each chapter includes theoretical background, practical exercises, and room for reflection.

Chapter 1 — Body: The Steadiness of “Here”

In this chapter The body is the indisputable ground of the present moment. We learn to sense gravity, posture, and our contact with space — the starting point of every practice.

Grounding through gravity — our steady base.

The Principle: Relaxation and Grounding

The practice of the Fourfold Axis always begins with the body. The body is our steady base, the unquestionable “Here” that anchors us in present time. We begin with conscious grounding, because relaxation comes before awareness.

Our body is not merely a vehicle. It is a living archive of our experience. The posture we have grown into often carries the rejection, disappointment, and strain we absorbed from feeling different. These experiences “lock in” as chronic tightness in the shoulders, the back, the pelvis, and the jaw.

Gravity: The Undeniable “Here”

Gravity is not just a force — it is the proof of “Here.” It shows us, beyond any doubt, the exact point where we can exist in space, in this very moment. Grounding is the first act of relaxation.

True grounding (Body) can only happen in a space we feel has room for us. Body and space work together.

Our Aim

- **Not:** to achieve some particular, perfect posture.
- **Not:** to stop our thoughts.
- **Yes:** to be comfortable, grounded, and at ease inside our own body.

Body, Space, and the Sense of Safety

Deep ease within the body is never an isolated act. It always presupposes an awareness of space. Through the sense organs, our body constantly informs us of where we are within space.

When space is perceived as open and receptive, the body receives permission to release its grip and relax. True grounding happens only in a space we feel can hold us.

Stepping Out of Concepts

When the mind has no steady, unquestionable base in the present, it easily falls into the trap of internal analysis and imagined scenarios. Focusing on gravity gives us a way out of these mental storylines.

Analysis and observation can happen in their own time, once stability is there. The content of the mechanical mind is recognized and released if it isn't useful — or if it's harmful — without any need for analysis. The open mind does not analyze or judge; it connects, and it understands causes.

An Undeniable “Here” and an Unbroken Flow: While gravity gives us an unshakable “Here,” at a larger scale there is only movement and flow (like the Earth circling the Sun). Mindfulness teaches us to embrace both poles: the steadiness of gravity and the ceaseless flow of life.

An important note about time: Changing posture and releasing tension takes real time — the habit was built over years, and the body has been molded by it. Don't rush, and don't push yourself. Persisting in gentleness is the greatest act of self-regulation there is.

Practice: The Book / The Box

- **Position:** Stand comfortably upright.
- **Prop (optional):** Take a book or a box and place it on your head.
- **Focus:** Notice how you need to stand so it doesn't fall. Feel the weight travel smoothly down through your neck, spine, and pelvis.
- **Sensation:** Feel the weight, the touch of your soles on the ground, and the sense of the axis holding you upright.

In the app: a guided [grounding exercise](#) · [Body microdoses](#) · for movement, [Swaying](#) and [Cloud Hands](#) (Tai Chi).

Reflection: After the exercise, what did I notice in my body?

★ **Key Point:** Gravity is always here. The body is always here. That is enough to begin.

Chapter 2 — Breath: The Rhythm of Life

In this chapter The breath connects us to the rhythm of life and teaches us to accept impermanence. Every inhale and exhale is a small rehearsal of beginning and ending.

The breath as a bridge between body and world.

If the body joins us to the earth, the breath connects us to the sky and to the ceaseless flow of the world. It is the rhythm that accompanies us from birth to the very end.

The Rhythm of Being

Watching the breath teaches us the natural rhythm of existence — and the acceptance of impermanence. Each inhale is held for a moment, and then released with the exhale.

- **INHALE** — The beginning: birth, receiving.
- **PAUSE** — The moment: being in the now.
- **EXHALE** — The ending: release, acceptance.

This is crucial for the neurodivergent mind: when we feel an intense emotion, the mind reads it as permanent. By watching the rhythm of the breath, we learn that every state is passing.

The Act of Observing — Inner Touch

The first step is acceptance. You don't need to control your breath. It is enough to observe it as it is: deep or shallow, slow or fast, free or held tight.

- The feeling of air touching the nostrils
- The expansion and contraction of the chest
- The movement of the belly
- The small shift in posture with each inhale and exhale

The breath as a gauge: If it is tight or shallow, it signals tension. If it is slow and deep, it signals ease. The breath is the gauge of our inner state.

Regulating in Acute Anxiety

In moments of intense anxiety or overload, the breath can become an immediate tool for regulation. We let the exhale leave through the mouth, a little slower and longer than usual. We allow the belly to soften and draw gently inward.

Practice: The Active Return

- **Grounding (Body):** Stand or sit comfortably. Feel gravity, feel your contact with the ground.
- **Awareness (Breath):** Turn your attention to the inhale and exhale. Feel the air touching your nostrils.
- **On the exhale:** Let the belly draw gently inward, as if you were releasing all the tension along with the air.
- **Acceptance:** Don't try to change the breath. Awareness alone is enough.
- **Regulation (optional):** If you feel very anxious, let the exhale leave through the mouth, slower and more drawn out.

The Axis of Presence

Through its movement, the breath strengthens the axis of presence that rests on gravity. It works as a counterweight to the stream of thoughts: the mind may race, but the breath keeps the body anchored in the now.

The tool here is twofold: to recognize the rhythm and quality of your breathing, and to feel how its movement supports the body–gravity axis, bringing you back against the current of thought.

The breath teaches us to observe without interfering. That capacity is the bridge to the next step: Attention.

In the app: [Guided 4-7-8 breathing](#) with an animated inhale/exhale guide · [Breath microdoses](#).

Reflection: What was my breath like during the exercise? (fast/slow, shallow/deep, tight/free)

★ **Key Point:** I observe without interfering. Every breath is a new beginning.

Chapter 3 — Attention: The Lens of Consciousness

In this chapter Attention is the mind’s lens — it can focus, open wide, or scatter. We learn to notice where it is, and to bring it back gently, without self-criticism.

Attention as a lens that illuminates the present moment.

Attention is the third center of consciousness, and the tool that decides where the mind will rest. The body is the base, the breath is the rhythm, and attention is the lens that lights up the present moment.

The Three Modes of Attention

Narrow attention. The beam gathers to a single point. Useful for concentration — for instance, gazing steadily at one object.

Open attention. The beam widens and illuminates many things at once. You hear the sounds, feel the body, breathe — everything fits within the same awareness.

Scattered attention. Attention behaves like a monkey leaping from branch to branch. The aim is not to “kill” it, but to rein it in gently.

The Trap of Fixated Attention

Beyond narrow and open attention there is a third state that deserves special care: fixated attention. The beam gets stuck — on an external object, or on some piece of mental content: a thought, a worry. Excessive self-referencing (“why do I feel this way? what does it mean?”) is a classic form of fixated attention.

Fourfold Attention

At this stage, attention becomes fourfold — we hold awareness of four layers at once:

- **Body** — which gives ground and steadiness to the present moment.
- **Breath** — which gives rhythm and keeps returning us to the now.
- **Attention itself** — which learns to stabilize, to notice where it goes.
- **Thoughts** — which are recognized without sweeping us away — simply observed.

The Power of the Label (Thought Labeling)

When a thought pulls at you, simply returning to the breath can be hard. The labeling technique gives you an intermediate step: instead of getting entangled in the thought's content, give it a simple one-word label — and then return to your anchor point.

- Thinking about what you have to do tomorrow → **“Planning”**
- Replaying something you said that came out wrong → **“Judging”** or **“Past”**
- Worrying about something ahead → **“Worry”** or **“Storyline”**

Practice: Steadying the Lens

- **Body & Breath:** Stand or sit comfortably. Close your eyes. Feel your body and the rhythm of your breathing.
- **Anchor point:** Open your eyes and choose a point of focus (visual, auditory, or bodily).
- **Fourfold awareness:** Keep your attention there while staying aware of body, breath, and passing thought-forms.
- **The gentle return:** If you drift, acknowledge it (with a label if needed) and come back softly: body → breath → anchor point.

In the app: [Attention microdoses](#) for training the lens.

Reflection: The journey of my attention — where does it tend to get “stuck,” or to “run”?

★ **Key Point:** Returning your attention is not failure — it is the exercise. Every gentle return lays down new neural pathways.

Chapter 4 — Space: Open Awareness

In this chapter The first three centers were things you *do*. Space is something that *already exists*. Here we meet awareness — the open field in which all experience happens — and learn to rest in it.

Space gives us the capacity to hold it all.

The Body gave us steadiness, the Breath gave us rhythm, Attention gave us the ability to return. All three are actions — something you direct, something you repeat, something that asks for a small, gentle effort. The fourth center is of a different nature. It is not one more technique in the sequence. It is the discovery of the field in which the first three were working all along.

The Field and Its Contents

Every moment of your experience has contents: a sound, a thought, a sensation in the chest, an image. Attention moves from content to content — that is its job. But all of these contents appear *somewhere*: within an open field that knows them.

That field is awareness.

The difference is simple, but it changes everything:

- **Attention** always has an object. It is selective — it lights up one thing at a time, and its capacity is limited.
- **Awareness** is not something *inside* the field. It is the field itself — that within which attention does its choosing.

Our habitual state is absorption in the contents: a thought arrives and we become the thought; a noise arrives and we become the irritation. The shift we learn here is to remember the field — the space that holds the thought, the noise, the irritation, without becoming any of them.

You Have Already Met It

Perhaps all this sounds new. It isn't. You have already met awareness — hundreds of times, in every exercise in this book.

Remember the “gentle return” from Chapter 3. The mind drifts off, and at some point there comes that sudden “oh — I was gone.” Now notice something: the return to the anchor point — you did that. But that instant of recognition — nobody did that. You didn't decide to realize you had drifted; if you could decide it, you would never have drifted at all. The recognition surfaced on its own.

That spontaneous flash has been studied in the laboratory, too — researchers of mind-wandering call it meta-awareness: the moment the mind notices, by itself, where it is. No one produces it on command. It appears.

Which means something liberating: **the fourth stage doesn't ask you to acquire anything new. It asks you to notice what has been alerting you from the start.**

Why Awareness Is Restful

Three features set awareness apart from attention — and each one matters directly to a neurodivergent nervous system:

Attention tires. Awareness doesn't. Focusing is an active function — it consumes. You know this better than anyone: attentional fatigue is a daily reality. But awareness doesn't *perform* anything — it simply knows. There is nothing in it to run down. That is why resting in the open field isn't one more exercise added to your load; it is the break from every load.

Attention gets interrupted. Awareness continues. Your focus breaks dozens of times a minute. But the field was never interrupted — otherwise, who would know about the interruption? Just as the sky doesn't leave when clouds cover it, awareness isn't lost when you forget it. You can only stop noticing it.

Attention narrows under pressure. Awareness holds everything. And here lies the most powerful tool in this chapter.

The Rhythm of Open Attention

The turn from narrow to open isn't only a change of perspective — it is a measurable change in how the brain works.

Research using neurofeedback (recording the brain's electrical activity in real time) has shown something remarkable: when attention clamps down on an object — especially under pressure — the brain runs in fast, unsynchronized rhythms of effort. But when attention spreads out and becomes peripheral, large regions of the brain fall into step in a slower rhythm — the so-called alpha waves, the rhythm of relaxed alertness. Present, awake, but without the grip.

And the most interesting finding of all: the fastest road to that rhythm is not trying to relax, but a question that has no object. Try it right now:

Can you feel the space between your two eyes?

Notice what just happened. Your attention moved — but found nothing to grasp. Space has no surface, no edge, no weight. And with nowhere to hook itself, attention's grip released on its own — and opened into the field. That is the whole secret of the peripheral vision we've been using since Chapter 2: when you give attention space as its "object," attention dissolves into awareness.

In the app: many breathing exercises in the [Sanctuary](#) are paired with binaural beats in the alpha frequency range — sound support for precisely this rhythm.

The Antidote to Overload

Now we can say precisely what this chapter has been saying all along: open attention is the most powerful tool against overload.

When we experience intense anxiety, the mind adopts a narrow focus, as if looking through a tunnel. That narrowing amplifies the sense of threat — whatever fits inside the tunnel becomes the entire world. Opening attention works as a safety signal to the brain: where there is space, there is no trap.

"The space of the sky remains forever open, undisturbed, and vast — and so does the space of awareness. Our identity is not the clouds, but the space that holds them."

One clarification, though — because here hides the most common misunderstanding: space is not something you *imagine*. If you paint a vast blue expanse in your mind and settle into it, you have simply made one more content — a beautiful image inside the field. Awareness is not the image of space; it is what knows the image. The sky here is a pointer, not a destination — like the finger pointing at the moon.

Short Moments, Many Times

Perhaps the most important news in this chapter: **awareness needs no duration.**

You don't have to "stay" in the open field for an hour — not even for minutes. One moment of real recognition is complete, however brief. Two seconds of open field are two whole seconds — not a failed version of ten minutes.

And here neuroplasticity (Chapter 10) says something that fits the neurodivergent mind perfectly: what lays down new pathways is not duration but *repetition*. Many short moments, scattered through the day, build familiarity with the open field more reliably than one long, effortful session. Over time the moments thicken — until the open becomes the place you return to by yourself, rather than a state you construct.

This principle is what the app's microdoses are built on — and so are Weeks 7 and 8 of the program, where the exercises last seconds. By the time you get there, you'll already know why.

One condition, always: opening happens safely only on a grounded body. The golden rule applies here too — here perhaps more than anywhere: first the earth, then the sky.

Practice: Widening the Space

- **Grounding:** Stand or sit comfortably. Close your eyes. Feel the body with its gravity and the breath with its rhythm.
- **Focus (narrow attention):** Settle on one point (sight, sound, or sensation) for a few seconds.
- **The objectless question:** Ask silently: "Can I feel the space between my eyes?" Don't search for an answer — let the question undo the grip.
- **Widening (open attention):** Let your attention spread out slowly — into the space around the sounds, around the body, in every direction.
- **Acceptance:** Hear, see, feel — without focusing and without judging. Contents come and go. You are the field.
- **Return:** If you get lost in a thought, the flash will come — "oh, I was gone." Smile: that flash *is* awareness. Return to the open.

In the app: [Space microdoses](#) for widening awareness.

Reflection: What changed in how I felt when my attention had nothing to grasp?

The Same Water

One last clarification, so the whole book isn't misread: the first three centers were not an "antechamber" we have now outgrown. Narrow focus and open awareness are complementary capacities of the same mind — the way the zoom and the wide lens are the same camera. You will keep using both, all your life; the freedom is in not being stuck in either.

And with time, the distinction softens on its own: the return becomes effortless, focus stops being a clench, and mindfulness and awareness stop being two things. The wave doesn't stop being a wave when it remembers it is water. It simply stops fighting the sea.

★ **Key Point:** Awareness is not something you construct — it is the field that has known every exercise of yours since page one. Short moments, many times, always on a grounded body.

Part 2 — Applications & Transformation

Strategies for everyday life.

Chapter 5 — The Neurodivergent Mind: Racing and Locking

In this chapter The neurodivergent mind is not broken — it works differently. We come to understand its two main states (racing / locking) and explore practical tools for each.

The mind of a neurodivergent person is rarely still. It usually moves between two extremes: it “races,” or it “locks.”

THE RACING MIND — Scattered attention / overload. The world becomes a chain of little hooks. Many stimuli arrive at once, unfiltered. *Tool: Body (grounding) + Breath (rhythm).*

THE LOCKING MIND — Fixated attention / hyperfocus. A tunnel of intense focus. It can become a trap when the object is an anxious thought or an obsession. *Tool: Space (release) + Attention (return).*

A strategy for rumination: Use open awareness (Space). Remember that your thoughts are happening inside a wider space. You can see their true size and find freedom, without letting them suffocate you.

The Role of the Mechanical Mind

Locking (hyperfocus) is often fed by the Mechanical Mind — the part of the mind that endlessly analyzes the past and plans the future, with no stable footing in the present. The Mechanical Mind is not an enemy. It is a tool that has “overheated” without the steadying influence of presence.

The practice does not try to stop the Mechanical Mind, but to complement it with an Open Mind — a mind that observes without analyzing, embraces without judging, sees past the storylines and perceives causes.

Kindness as the Way Off Autopilot

Self-criticism is not your own truth — it is an echo of words, looks, and expectations that went unmet. Neuroscience shows that self-criticism activates the same circuits in the brain (the amygdala, cortisol) as external danger. Every time you judge yourself harshly, your brain responds as if it were under attack.

The gentleness of this method is the stance we need to hold toward ourselves. Growth here doesn’t mean productivity — it means the flowering of your own singular potential.

Remember: your thoughts and experiences are happening inside a wider space of awareness. Within that open space, you can see them at their true size. Treat yourself the way you would treat a friend who is struggling.

Reflection: My own patterns — when does my mind tend to “race”? When does it “lock”? What situations trigger each?

Chapter 6 — In Everyday Life: Self-Regulation

In this chapter Practical tools for noisy places, social situations, and moments of stress or tension in daily life.

Self-regulation is the ability to bring your nervous system back into balance — down from overdrive, or up from shutdown. It begins with contact on four levels:

- **Contact with the Body** — You feel the ground, your weight, your axis.
- **Contact with the Breath** — You notice whether its rhythm is fast, shallow, or calm.
- **Contact with Attention** — You see where the mind has caught (scattering or fixating).
- **Contact with Space** — You sense whether there is openness and safety.

Practical Applications

1. In Noisy Places (Sensory Overload)

- Feel your feet on the floor — instant grounding in the middle of chaos.
- Take 3 quiet breaths, exhaling through the mouth.
- Open your peripheral vision — soften the gaze instead of zooming in.
- Use headphones or a fidget toy if you need them.

2. In Social Moments (Overstimulation & Fatigue)

- Choose a neutral point (a plant, say) as a visual reference.
- Feel your feet planted — if there's tension in your jaw, let it go with an exhale.
- Use peripheral vision to stay present.

3. With Stress or Tension (Immediate Regulation)

- Ground: feel your weight and your axis.
- Take 10 breaths: in through the nose, out through the mouth, slowly.
- Walk with awareness (mindful pacing) — rhythmic movement “burns off” the anxiety.

Chapter 7 — When the Wave Rises: Anxiety, Overload

In this chapter Two practical protocols — one for acute anxiety, one for overload. Simple steps that can become automatic when the wave rises.

Protocol 1: Meeting Acute Anxiety

Acute anxiety is a fight-or-flight state that calls for an immediate safety signal to the nervous system, through body and breath.

- **Ground (Body)** — Feel your body’s weight, its posture, its points of tension — without putting anything into words. Just notice where you’re holding on.
- **Regulate (Breath)** — Close your eyes and take 3 deep breaths. Let the exhale leave slowly through the mouth, as if softly blowing on a flame.
- **Label (Attention)** — If the mind snags on a storyline, use a label (“Worry,” “Storyline”) and come back to the breath.
- **Open (Space)** — Open your peripheral vision and take in the space around you. Widening reduces the feeling of being trapped.
- **Movement & Axis** — If you can, walk a little, feeling your soles. Keep the sense of your vertical axis. Open gaze, awareness of space.

Protocol 2: Managing Overload

When everything is crashing in at once, the aim is to find room to hold the stimuli without reacting. Instead of trying to lower the anxiety, you widen the awareness.

- **Ground (Stage 1)** — Feel your soles, your weight. Reset your position, as if pressing your body’s reset button.
- **Breath (Stage 2)** — Stay with its flow. Exhaling through the mouth is optional, but recommended if you feel constricted.
- **Attention (Stage 3)** — Keep your attention out in front. Instead of being dragged along by every detail, choose one steady point as your anchor.
- **Open (Space — Stage 4)** — Soften your gaze (peripheral vision). Remember the sky: every stimulus — sounds, lights, thoughts — is a cloud passing through the open space of your awareness.

Keep the distance: Remember — you are not the clouds. You are the space that holds them. Simply recognizing this immediately lowers the sense of threat.

Reflection: What are my body’s first signals when overload begins?

Chapter 8 — The Presence Worksheet

Aim: To come back to the “now” in a matter of seconds. Do the steps in order, or pick whichever one you need.

1. BODY / GROUND

- *Notice:* I’m standing / sitting. I feel my weight. I notice tension (the jaw, for instance).
- *Tool:* I picture an axis running from my head down into the earth. I relax the jaw and shoulders.
- *What did I just feel in my body?*

2. BREATH / RHYTHM

- *Notice:* How is my breath? Fast, shallow, tight?
- *Tool:* Exhale through the mouth, a little slower. Feel the belly draw gently in.
- *How did my breath change?*

3. ATTENTION / STEADYING

- *Notice:* Where is my attention? Is it racing? Stuck somewhere?
- *Tool:* I return to a steady point. I label the thought and come back.
- *Where had my attention gone?*

4. SPACE / EXPANSION

- *Notice:* Do I feel trapped? Is my attention like a tunnel?
- *Tool:* I soften my gaze. I let attention spread out. Thoughts = clouds.
- *What changed when the space opened?*

Chapter 9 — The Four Stages: A Step-by-Step Guide

This is the full, sequential practice of the Fourfold Axis. It works best in a quiet spot, but the steps can be applied at any moment.

The Attitude Behind the Steps

Before you begin the stages, remember: gentleness is not optional — it *is* the method. Every time you return without judgment, every time you accept distraction as part of the process, you are practicing kindness. Not as an idea — as an act.

Self-criticism activates the same neural circuits as external danger. The gentle return calms them. That is the path: not fighting the autopilot, but giving it room to settle.

Treat yourself the way you would treat a friend who is struggling.

Stage 1 — Feel the Earth (Grounding)

- Sit or stand comfortably. Back upright but not rigid.
- Feel the points of contact: soles, back against the seat.
- Let your weight sink into the earth.
- With each exhale, relax the neck, jaw, shoulders.
- **Aim:** To feel the vertical axis — your base.

Stage 2 — Feel the Breath (Regulation)

- Close or half-close your eyes.

- Feel the route: inhale through the nose → lungs → belly, exhale in reverse.
- Under tension: exhale slowly through the mouth, as if blowing on a candle.
- **Aim:** A natural, unbroken rhythm — a settled nervous system.

Stage 3 — Focus Ahead (Concentration)

- Open your eyes. Choose a quiet point in front of you.
- Look at it with a soft, steady gaze.
- If thoughts come: acknowledge → label → return gently.
- **Aim:** Training attention to hold steady.

Stage 4 — Open into Space (Open Awareness)

- Soften the gaze. Open your peripheral vision.
- Take in the whole visual field: right, left, above, below.
- Feel it all at once: body, breath, earth, sky.
- **Aim:** A direct sense of presence, without words or effort.

In the app: the full guided practice and the step-by-step [structured program](#) · the [practice space](#) with all the exercises.

Reflection: Which stage feels most natural to me? Where do I struggle most?

Chapter 10 — The Background: Science and Wisdom

Part A: The Scientific Background

Grounding & Interoception. Focusing on gravity strengthens interoception (awareness of inner bodily sensations) and cerebellar function, deepening the felt sense of bodily safety.

Breath & the Vagus Nerve. A slow, deep exhale sends safety signals through the vagus nerve, dialing down the fight-or-flight response and bringing immediate calm.

Attention & the Prefrontal Cortex. Learning to steer attention and to use labeling strengthens the prefrontal cortex — the seat of impulse control and decision-making.

Space & the Default Mode Network (DMN). Open awareness reduces activity in the DMN — the network behind chronic over-analysis and looping thoughts — creating cognitive distance.

Neuroplasticity. Our brain can change. Sustained practice builds new neural pathways, making calm and presence easier and easier to reach.

Part B: The Contemplative Background

Mahāsatiṭṭhāna Sutta. The Four Foundations of Mindfulness (body, feelings, mind, mental phenomena) map directly onto the four stages of our method.

Dzogchen. Traditions such as Dzogchen speak of recognizing the “open space” of consciousness, in which thoughts and emotions appear and dissolve without confining us.

Sufism. Sufism reminds us of the importance of grounding, and of the heart as center — the joining of spirit and body.

In short: Science and the contemplative traditions agree — balance begins in the body, is regulated by the breath, is steadied by attention, and expands into a sense of vastness.

Resources & Going Further

- Open Focus — <https://openfocus.com/home/>
- Short Moments of Open Intelligence — <https://www.holybooks.com/wp-content/uploads/Short-Moments-of-Open-Intelligence.pdf>
- Lama Lena — Dzogchen — <https://lamalenateachings.com/>
- Merigar — International Dzogchen Community — <https://www.merigar.it/en/dzogchen-community/>
- Sufism — <https://sufi.gr/>

Part 3 — The 8-Week Program

This is the complete, guided program — the practical path built on the theory of the previous parts. It is organized around the four axes, two weeks each (Body, Breath, Attention, Space), with one small practice per day. There is no hurry and no “failing” — even distraction is part of the learning.

The golden rule: before every exercise, begin with a few seconds of grounding in the body.

Body / Earth

Week 1 — Body / Earth: Gravity & Axis

Day 1 — Gravity vs. the “Autopilot” *Anywhere · 1 second*

Ours is a method of *self-soothing*, not of forced self-concentration. There is no hurry, no strain, no “failure” — everything is learning, even distraction.

The Default Mode Network (DMN) — the brain’s “autopilot” — generates mind-wandering. Today we run an experiment: we feel gravity, to restore bodily sensation and wake up our proprioceptive sense. Gravity alone won’t switch the autopilot off for good (that takes open awareness), but it is the first step back to the Now.

Exercise — Feel the Gravity:

- At some point during the day, remember:
- Stop whatever you’re doing for 1 second.
- Simply feel the weight of your body “dropping.”
- If you drift off, return gently — no criticism.

Breath: Nothing required — No breathing exercise today. We only observe.

Reflection: What was it like to switch the sense of gravity back on?

★ Gravity brings the body back to the present. It is the first anchor.

Day 2 — The Axis as Safety *Anywhere · 1 second*

We are building a relaxed presence. The tighter you are, the narrower your attention — and your sense of the space around you.

Today we add the “axis.” Besides the gravity pulling you down, there is an imagined vertical line holding you upright. That axis is your safety. It keeps you steady and open, with no need to tense up.

Exercise — The 1-Second Pause:

- Whenever you remember during the day:

- Pause (1 second).
- Feel gravity drawing you down.
- Feel the vertical axis holding you upright — and at ease.

Breath: Natural breathing — Let your body breathe however it wants to.

Reflection: Could I feel that “imagined line” inside me without tensing up?

★ Your axis keeps you upright and aligned — structure without strain.

Day 3 — Feel the Soles of Your Feet *Anywhere · 2 seconds*

Our soles are our main radar for the ground. For many neurodivergent people, contact with the floor brings enormous reassurance.

Today the experiment centers on the point of contact.

Exercise — Contact with the Ground:

- At some point in the day, pause.
- Feel the contact of your soles with your shoes or the floor.
- Is your footing steady?
- One or two seconds is enough.
- Carry on with your day.

Breath: 5-5 breathing — **Optional:** You can begin the 5-5 rhythm (inhale 5, exhale 5) — only if it feels comfortable.

Reflection: Did I feel more grounded once I noticed my soles?

★ The ground is always there to hold you up.

Day 4 — Legs and Axis *Anywhere · 5 minutes*

We join the feeling in the soles with the axis we learned on Day 2. Imagine the axis beginning at your soles and rising straight up.

Exercise — Connecting Legs to Axis:

- Stop for a moment (standing or seated).
- Feel your soles.
- Let your attention travel gradually up your legs.
- Feel how the legs connect into the axis of the torso.

Breath: Calm breathing — If you like, keep the 5-5 rhythm.

Reflection: Can I feel my legs as the foundations of the axis?

★ The heavier the foundations, the lighter the torso.

Day 5 — Legs, Axis & Pelvis *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

The pelvis is the body's center of gravity. It is the "flowerpot" in which your axis takes root.

Today we bring our attention to the region of the pelvis.

Exercise — The Center of Gravity:

- Sit back comfortably, or stand.
- Feel your soles and legs.
- Bring your attention up to the pelvis. If you're sitting, feel its weight.
- Feel how your axis grows up out of it.

Breath: 5-5 with pelvic awareness — Take a 5-second inhale and feel the air travel all the way down to the pelvis. Exhale for 5.

Reflection: Is my pelvis tense, or at ease?

★ The pelvis is our point of safety and balance.

Day 6 — Head, Arms, Legs, Axis *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

Now the body map spreads out. So far we've had legs, pelvis, and axis. Today we add the arms and the head.

Everything connects into the central axis.

Exercise — Expanding into Space:

- Soles, legs, pelvis, axis.
- Add the arms: feel their weight hanging.
- Add the head: balancing perfectly on top of the axis.
- Feel the whole body as one connected, unified whole.

Breath: 5-5 breathing — Keep the steady rhythm of balance.

Reflection: Which part of my body could I feel least clearly?

★ When we can feel the whole body, the brain feels safer.

Day 7 — Mindful Walking (Slow Walking) *Open space or hallway · 10 minutes*

Steadiness is not stillness. It is keeping our center (the axis) while we move through space.

Today we bring mindfulness into a very slow walk.

Exercise — Walking with Awareness:

- Begin walking very slowly.
- Feel each phase of the step: heel — sole — toes.
- Keep your awareness on your axis, your arms, your head.

- Feel how your balance shifts.

Breath: Natural rhythm — Link the breath to your steps. For example, inhale for 2 steps, exhale for 2 steps.

Reflection: Did I feel steadier walking slowly?

★ Unhurried movement deeply soothes the nervous system.

Week 2 — Body / Earth: Going Deeper

Day 1 — Full Scan & Pause *Quiet place · 10 minutes*

The second week opens with a scan of the first week's tools: gravity, axis, soles, pelvis, arms, head.

We pause, and we observe.

Exercise — A Safety Body Scan:

- Stand or sit comfortably.
- Begin at the soles — feel them. Move gradually upward.
- Feel the knees, the pelvis, the torso (the axis).
- Feel the shoulders, the arms (their weight).
- Feel the neck and the head.
- Pause for 30 seconds, sensing the “whole.”

Breath: 5-5 breathing — Keep a gentle 5-5 rhythm through the scan.

Reflection: Is there a spot that keeps drawing my attention?

★ A clear map of the body lowers the felt sense of anxiety.

Day 2 — Releasing the Shoulders & the Axis *Anywhere · 5 minutes*

Today we focus on a place that holds a great deal of tension: the shoulders. We learn to hand their weight over to gravity while keeping the central axis strong.

Exercise — Deselecting Tension (Shoulders):

- Stand or sit with your axis aligned.
- Bring your attention to your shoulders. Feel how you're holding them.
- On an exhale, simply let them drop — giving their weight to the earth.
- The axis stays tall; the shoulders land, heavy and grounded.

Breath: The releasing exhale — With every exhale, the shoulders settle a few millimeters lower.

Reflection: How much tension was I carrying in my shoulders without knowing it?

★ Real steadiness (the axis) doesn't need clenching.

Day 3 — Releasing the Neck & the Axis *Anywhere · 5 minutes*

We continue the release from the top down. The neck supports the head on the axis.

Exercise — Head & Neck:

- Find your central axis.
- Bring attention to the neck. Feel the head balancing without effort.
- Make small, barely visible movements left and right to “unlock” the neck.
- Give the weight over to gravity.

Breath: Calm breathing — Your breath’s rhythm (5-5) supports the axis.

Reflection: Did my neck soften at all?

★ Focus doesn’t have to be static.

Day 4 — Pelvis, Belly, Full Scan (Soles to Head) *Quiet place · 10 minutes*

Today the scan deepens with attention to the belly. For many people, the belly is the “mirror” of their tension.

Exercise — A Scan Centered on the Middle:

- Begin scanning from the soles upward.
- When you reach the pelvis, stay there.
- Bring attention to the belly. Is it tight? Let it “drop” — let it relax completely (soft belly).
- Continue the scan through the chest, arms, head.

Breath: Belly breathing (soft belly) — Inhale: the belly rounds gently. Exhale: the belly falls.

Reflection: Could I let my belly relax, instead of holding it “in”?

★ A soft belly sends an immediate “safe” signal to the brain (via the vagus nerve).

Day 5 — Scan & Balance *Quiet place · 10 minutes*

Today, as we scan the body, we focus on the big joints — knees, pelvis — and how they govern our balance.

Exercise — Joints & Balance:

- Stand upright. Scan from the soles up to the pelvis.
- Stop at the knees: are they hyper-extended (too straight, too rigid)? Bend them just BARELY (a micro-bend).
- Stop at the pelvis: find your center of balance.
- Feel the safety (belly soft).

Breath: 5-5 breathing — Keep the rhythm (or 4-7-8 for relaxation, if that feels better).

Reflection: Did I feel the difference with “unlocked” knees?

★ When we unlock the knees, we let energy and weight flow down into the earth.

Day 6 — Axis & Mindful Walking *Outdoors or at home · 10 minutes*

Today we join movement and stillness. The real test of mindfulness is keeping the sense of your center (your axis) under all conditions.

Exercise — Movement and Pause:

- Begin with slow mindful walking (3 minutes).
- Stop abruptly. Feel your soles and your axis (1 minute).
- Feel the grounding; find your center again.
- Return to walking.
- Experiment with different walking speeds.

Breath: Rhythmic breathing — See if your breath can stay unaffected by the changes in movement.

Reflection: How easy was it to find my balance right after walking?

★ The axis is there in movement and in stillness alike.

Day 7 — Metronome & Slow Walking *Quiet place / hallway · 10 minutes*

The final day of the Body section. We bring in RHYTHM. Rhythm is deeply regulating — and especially important for autistic people and people with ADHD.

Exercise — Moving to a Beat / Metronome:

- Use an imagined or a real metronome (or the beats in our Binaural Beats).
- Walk in time with the tempo: 1, 2, 1, 2. (3 minutes)
- Stop and find your axis. (1 minute)
- Feel the beat (the metronome) still pulsing inside you while you stand still.
- Repeat, letting the body follow freely.

Breath: Breathing in rhythm — Match the breath to the beats/steps (e.g., 2 steps in, 2 steps out).

Reflection: How did my nervous system respond to the rhythm?

★ Rhythm gives the brain predictability — and predictability brings calm.

Breath / Sky

Week 3 — Breath / Sky: The Current of Life

Day 1 — Introducing the Breath *Anywhere · 5 minutes*

From today onward, every day, we remember the golden rule: **begin with a few seconds of grounding** before any exercise.

Today we simply read the chapter on the breath. The breath is our anchor.

Exercise — Observing Without Interfering:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Simply notice: how are you breathing, right now?
- Don't try to change it.
- We keep awareness only.

Breath: Natural breathing — No interference.

Reflection: Did my breath change the moment I gave it my attention?

★ Observation, all by itself, is an act of care.

Day 2 — Inner Touch at the Nostrils *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

The breath offers a kind of “inner touch.” We feel the air touching us from the inside.

Today the point of focus is the nostrils, as the air moves in and out.

Exercise — Focus at the Nostrils:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Bring your attention to your nostrils.
- Where exactly do you feel the air?
- During the day, take small pauses and recall that sensation.

Breath: Natural flow — Feel the coolness of the inhale and the warmth of the exhale.

Reflection: Can I feel the air more distinctly in the right or the left nostril?

★ Inner touch is the most direct way to ground ourselves in the body.

Day 3 — Throat & Rhythmic Breathing *Quiet place · 5–10 minutes*

We move the attention a little lower, to the throat — where the air passes and makes a sound. Today we experiment with two rhythms.

Exercise — Watching at the Throat & Two Rhythms:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Feel the breath passing through your throat.
- Begin with the 5-5 rhythm (inhale 5, exhale 5).
- Then try 4-2-7 (inhale 4, hold 2, exhale 7).
- Notice which rhythm calms you more.

Breath: 5-5 and 4-2-7 — Rhythm directly changes the workings of our control center.

Reflection: Which of the two rhythms felt more natural to me?

★ Different rhythms act differently on our nervous system.

Day 4 — The Belly, Rising and Falling *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

We descend to the base of the breath: the belly. When the belly rises and falls freely, the body knows it is safe.

Exercise — Belly Breathing:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Rest one hand on your belly.
- Watch the belly round with the inhale.
- At the end, watch only the exhale, as the belly “empties.”

Breath: Exhaling from the belly — Notice especially how the belly relaxes as the air empties out.

Reflection: Was it easy to breathe with my belly unlocked?

★ A soft belly lets the deep breath do its healing work.

Day 5 — The Route: Nose — Throat — Lungs *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

Today we join the pieces. The air is a current traveling through us.

Exercise — Following the Route:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Follow one complete inhale.
- Nose → throat → lungs.
- Follow the return journey on the exhale.

Breath: Circular awareness — Your attention travels along with the air.

Reflection: Could I follow the air along its whole route?

★ When the mind travels with the breath, there’s no room left for anxious thoughts.

Day 6 — The Whole Breath and Its Pauses *Anywhere · 5 minutes*

We read the section on the pauses. Between the inhale and the exhale there is a small gap — a natural “pause.” That is where the quiet lives.

Exercise — Noticing the Pauses:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Observe the whole (the whole body breathing).
- Notice the little pause at the end of the inhale, before you exhale.

- Notice the little pause at the end of the exhale, before you breathe in again.
- Through the day, simply rest there.

Breath: The whole breath, with pauses — A quiet stop within the flow.

Reflection: How did the moment of the pause feel?

★ In the pause we wait for nothing. We simply are.

Day 7 — Opening the Chest & the Breath *Open space · 10 minutes*

We combine the breath with the body's movement in a simple way, to create more room.

Exercise — Opening with the Rhythm of the Breath:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- As you inhale, open the chest slightly and roll the shoulders back.
- As you exhale, release completely, letting the body return to its neutral posture.
- Repeat several times, at your own pace.

Breath: Synchronization — Opening = inhale. Releasing = exhale.

Reflection: Could I synchronize the body with the breath?

★ Movement without forcing makes the breath deeper — and safer.

Week 4 — Breath / Sky: Movement & Kindness

Day 1 — Review: Nostrils & 5-5 *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

We open the fourth week by blending the tools of the previous days. Today we recall the inner touch at the nostrils.

Exercise — Nostrils and Rhythm Together:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Begin by focusing at the nostrils.
- Apply the 5-5 rhythm (inhale 5, exhale 5) while staying there.
- Keep your attention on the inner touch.

Breath: 5-5 at the nostrils — Attention held in a steady loop.

Reflection: How easy was it to stay at the nostrils?

★ Repetition is how the nervous system learns.

Day 2 — Review: Throat & 4-2-7 *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

We continue with the throat — and the pause that allows a deeper release (the 4-2-7 rhythm).

Exercise — Throat with a Long Exhale:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Bring your awareness to your throat.
- Inhale for 4 seconds; hold for 2.
- Exhale for 7 seconds, feeling the air in the throat.

Breath: 4-2-7 breathing — We switch on the calming system.

Reflection: What happened in my body with the long exhale?

★ A longer exhale is the finest regulator there is.

Day 3 — Review: Belly & the Breath of Pauses *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

We return to the center of gravity: the belly. When the belly rises and falls freely, the body feels safe.

Exercise — Belly and Pause:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Rest a hand on the belly. Feel it round.
- At the top of the inhale (belly full), notice the natural pause.
- At the end of the exhale, notice the natural pause before the next breath comes.

Breath: Pausing at the belly — The belly “rests” between the cycles.

Reflection: Could I stay in the pause without getting anxious?

★ In the pause hides the deepest kind of trust.

Day 4 — Sounding Breath (Chanting) *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

Making sound (like humming) creates a vibration that massages the vagus nerve, settling the body.

It needn't carry any religious tone. Today we'll use a single note (middle C, say) or simply the sound “Ah.” If you have a mantra of your own from your tradition, you're welcome to use it (optional).

Explore the “Chanting & Resonance” (Humming) practices

Exercise — Vibration with the Sound “Ah”:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Take a calm inhale.
- On the exhale, let out a low, sustained “Ahhh” — or the note C.
- Feel the vibration in your throat and chest.
- Repeat for a few cycles.

Breath: Exhaling with sound — Sound naturally lengthens the exhale.

Reflection: Did anything in my body change with the vibration of the sound?

★ Sound is a tool of the nervous system. Vibration shakes the tension loose.

Day 5 — Mindful Movement: Opening the Arms & Kindness *Open space · 5 minutes*

We introduce a new mindful movement: opening the arms toward the sky and the heart. Here we add the intention of kindness (metta) toward all.

Exercise — Opening to the Universe:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- On the inhale, open your arms wide and upward (to the sky). Unfold the chest (the heart).
- As you open, feel warmth and kindness toward yourself and toward everyone.
- On the exhale, lower the arms gently to your sides.

Breath: The widening inhale — The chest opens; the heart “breathes.”

Reflection: What feeling did the opening of the arms bring up?

★ The body’s posture shapes our feeling — and our intention — profoundly.

Day 6 — Going Deeper: Opening to the Sky *Open space · 5 minutes*

We repeat the same mindful movement, focusing even more on the sensation in the chest and the heart.

Exercise — The Heart Center:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Begin the movement: arms opening, heart opening.
- Silently think: “May I be well. May all beings be well,” as you breathe in from the chest.
- The movement becomes a prayer of kindness.

Breath: Breathing from the heart — The inhale as opening.

Reflection: Was there any resistance to kindness in me?

★ Kindness isn’t just a thought. It is something the body feels.

Day 7 — Completion: Body, Breath & Kindness *Open space · 10 minutes*

Today the second axis comes to completion. We have connected body, breath, movement, and kindness.

As we’ve said, there are ten mindful movements in total, which we’ll use later (by center) once the weeks are complete.

Explore the “Chanting & Resonance” (Humming) practices

Exercise — The Final Breath Practice:

- Ground in the body (10 seconds).
- Observe the rhythm (5-5) for 2 minutes.
- Mindful movement: the Bow (2 minutes).
- Opening the arms to the sky + kindness (metta) (2 minutes).
- Pause and observe the effect in the body (2 minutes).

Breath: Natural breath as the closing note — End the practice by letting everything go.

Reflection: How do my body and my breath feel after 4 weeks?

★ You have already built a strong foundation of self-regulation.

Attention / Fire

Week 5 — Attention / Fire: Focus and Light

Day 1 — Introducing Attention *Anywhere · A few minutes*

Before every exercise: **first we feel our axis, our gravity, and our breath — and we tune them gently.** That is our base.

Reading: our attention is the lens that lights up our experience.

Exercise — A 7-Second Gaze:

- Grounding, axis, breath. (30 seconds)
- Take small pauses through the day.
- Look steadily at any object for 7 seconds.
- Return to what you were doing.

Breath: Soft observation for 7 seconds — Keep the breath calm while you look.

Reflection: What did I actually see in those 7 seconds?

★ Seven seconds of attention are enough to break the day's autopilot.

Day 2 — Alternating Attention *Anywhere · 5 minutes*

We keep sharpening the “lens” of attention by moving our focus deliberately. Moving the gaze rests the nervous system.

Exercise — Right — Left:

- Grounding, axis, breath.
- Choose one object to your right and one to your left.

- Look at the right one with focus. Feel your breath.
- Shift your gaze to the left one. Feel your breath.
- Alternate slowly, a few times.

Breath: Attention and rhythm — Keep the rhythm (5-5, say) as you alternate.

Reflection: Did anything shift in my body as I moved my focus?

★ When you direct your attention deliberately, you take back the controls.

Day 3 — A Visual Anchor *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

If you imagine your field of vision as a camera, today you set the “camera” exactly at eye level. That is your anchor.

Exercise — Anchor at Eye Level:

- Grounding, axis, soft breath.
- Find a point exactly at the height of your eyes.
- Stay there. The gaze neither rises nor falls.
- Let your attention become one with the point.

Breath: A steady anchor — A steady gaze quiets the thinking.

Reflection: How easy was it to keep my “camera” (my gaze) from moving?

★ A fixed point of reference creates inner stability.

Day 4 — Soles, Breath, Object *Anywhere · 5 minutes*

We string three levels of attention on a single thread: the Earth (soles), the Air (breath), and Space (an object).

Exercise — Threefold Focus:

- Begin with grounding (feel your soles).
- Observe the breath and tune it.
- Focus on an object.
- Now try to feel all three at once: soles — breath — object.

Breath: Synchronizing attention — We widen the field of attention without losing our center.

Reflection: Can I hold three things in my attention at once?

★ The capacity of your awareness is greater than you think.

Day 5 — Narrow and Open Attention *Throughout the day · Short pauses*

Our attention has a zoom. Sometimes it closes in (zoom in — narrow), sometimes it takes in the whole field (zoom out — open).

Exercise — Switching the Lens:

- In moments through the day: grounding, breath.
- Focus on one small point (narrow attention).
- Soften the gaze; see the whole space peripherally (open attention).
- Stay in open attention for a few seconds.

Breath: Zoom in / zoom out — One breath for gathering, one for widening.

Reflection: Where do I feel more at home — in narrow attention, or in open?

★ Fear narrows the gaze. Calm opens it.

Day 6 — 12 Seconds of Steadiness *Quiet place · 5 minutes*

We raise the bar from Day 1. Twelve seconds is enough to change your inner state completely.

Exercise — The 12-Second Anchor:

- Grounding, axis, soft breath.
- Body: feel the body in space.
- Breath: observe the rhythm.
- Focus on one point, STEADILY, for 12 seconds.
- Don't let the eyes or the mind wander off until the 12 seconds have passed.

Breath: 5-5 in steadiness — 12 seconds is just over one full breath cycle.

Reflection: Did the 12 seconds feel long, or short?

★ A few seconds of pure presence can erase hours of absence.

Day 7 — From the Point to the Space *Anywhere · 5 minutes*

We combine the tools: first the sharp focus (which brings presence), then the widening (which brings rest).

Exercise — Melting the Lens:

- Grounding, axis, soft breath.
- Lock your attention onto ONE point.
- Feel the sharpness of your gaze.
- Slowly begin to see the space AROUND the point.
- Allow your attention to become open and peripheral.

Breath: The releasing breath — From control to acceptance.

Reflection: How did it feel the moment the lens “opened”?

★ You don't have to hold the world up by yourself. The space holds you.

Week 6 — Attention / Fire: Settling into Calm

Day 1 — Narrow and Open Attention *Quiet place · 10 minutes*

We enter Week 6; our aim now is consolidation. We begin by strengthening the transition from the one thing (an object) to the whole.

Exercise — Crossing into Space:

- Always: grounding, breath, axis.
- Lock your attention onto an object in front of you.
- Stay there for a while.
- Release the focus all at once (open attention) and simply take in the whole scene.
- Repeat three times.

Breath: The rhythm of transition — Gathering in the narrow, widening in the open.

Reflection: Is the switch from focus to release easier now?

★ The ability to relax is every bit as useful as the ability to concentrate.

Day 2 — Thoughts as Objects (Samatha) *Quiet place · 10 minutes*

Picture your mind as a field of vision. Thoughts are simply objects (like clouds, or bubbles) that enter that field and pass through. This practice is called samatha (calm abiding).

Exercise — Watching Thoughts:

- Grounding, axis, rhythmic breath.
- Close your eyes. Picture the field of your mind.
- A thought arrives. See it as an object.
- Don't hold on to it. Watch it cross the field of view and leave.
- You remain the steady observer.

Breath: Samatha breathing — A stable base while the “objects” pass by.

Reflection: Did I manage not to merge with any of the thoughts?

★ You are not your thoughts. You are the space in which they happen.

Day 3 — Settling into Calm *Daily life & evening · 10 minutes*

We enter a phase of consolidation — practicing what we've learned until it takes root. And we introduce a new evening routine.

Exercise — 5-5 and the Evening Routine:

- During the day: the 5-5 breathing exercise (inhale 5 / exhale 5).

- Calming breath (little pauses) whenever you need it.
- **Evening routine:** “I quiet down, I slow the pace.”
- Before sleep: grounding in bed, deep exhales, letting the day go.

Breath: 5-5 and the calming breath — The rhythm of steadiness.

Reflection: Did the evening routine help my sleep?

★ Whatever is repeated becomes part of you.

Day 4 — The Echo of the Past (Vipassana) *In the mind · 10 minutes*

Out of calm observation (samatha), insight (vipassana) begins to arise. As you sit and watch, the critical “echo of the past” often shows itself.

You see the contents of your consciousness clearly — and you realize how they’ve been trying to steer you from backstage.

Exercise — Changing the Helmsman:

- When you notice a critical thought (the echo), acknowledge it.
- Don’t fight it. Simply let it go, as “not useful.”
- In its place, put presence (grounding) — with kindness and openness.
- You change helmsmen: from the unconscious churn to conscious, open presence.

Breath: The breath of acceptance — Breathe in presence; breathe out what isn’t useful.

Reflection: Could I see my “self-criticism” as a mere echo — and not as the truth?

★ You are free, now, to choose who steers your mind.

Day 5 — The Mental Mantra *Anywhere · 10 minutes*

If the mind is racing through dark scenarios and simply watching the thoughts feels impossible, give it something to do.

Use a silent chant or mantra with no religious tone — a song line, say, like “always look on the bright side of life,” or something from your own tradition if you wish. It keeps the mind occupied without feeding it anything painful.

Exercise — Replacing with a Mantra:

- When the mind gets caught in a dark storyline:
- Grounding, axis, rhythmic breath.
- Begin silently repeating the phrase or mantra you’ve chosen.
- Each time the mind slides back to the storyline, return gently to the mantra.

Breath: Rhythm with the mantra — Link the syllables of the phrase to your breath.

Reflection: Did the mantra help interrupt the dark storyline?

★ We often can't stop the mind — but we can give it a harmless occupation.

Day 6 — Presence Everywhere, with Kindness *Anywhere · Ongoing practice*

The consistency of the past days is bearing fruit. “Open attention” is becoming second nature — always signed with simple kindness toward ourselves.

Exercise — The Effortless Anchor:

- Through the day, without straining: remember your soles and one visual point.
- Your breath finds its rhythm often (5-5).
- If you drift, return gently, without reproach (self-compassion).
- Evening routine of surrendering into sleep.

Breath: 5-5 as second nature — The rhythm finds itself on its own.

Reflection: Was I kinder to myself today when I got distracted?

★ Mindfulness is the returning — not the absence of distraction.

Day 7 — Completing the Consolidation *Anywhere · 15 minutes*

We reach the end of the sixth week, where Attention, Space, and the mind's new, open “helmsman” have begun to settle into daily life.

Exercise — Review and Routine:

- Grounding, axis, gravity.
- Calming breath (rhythmic 5-5).
- Remember: narrow attention (zoom in) and open attention (zoom out).
- Thoughts as passing objects (samatha/vipassana).
- We close the week with the evening routine.

Breath: Tuning before sleep — A day that ends in calm brings a clear morning.

Reflection: What was the most useful tool of these two weeks?

★ You don't need to push your mind. It's enough to let it rest in open space.

Space / Water

Week 7 — Space / Water: Open Awareness

Day 1 — The 4 Centers & the Sky *Anywhere / outdoors · 5–10 minutes*

From this week on, we bring the 4 centers together (Body, Breath, Attention, Space). We learn “open attention.”

Every day: **sky gazing**. Set aside a little time to look at the sky and breathe through it.

Exercise — Sky Gazing:

- Open your attention a little in the morning, at midday, and in the evening.
- A few times a day, look up at the sky.
- Take a deep breath, feeling the boundless space.

Breath: Breathing from the sky — Imagine you are breathing from the vast space of the sky itself.

Reflection: Could I feel open attention today?

★ The sky is always there, behind the clouds.

Day 2 — Open Attention, 3 Times a Day *Anywhere · A few minutes*

We continue joining the 4 centers. Body, breath, attention, and space become one.

Practice open attention a little in the morning, a little at midday, a little in the evening.

Exercise — An Open-Attention Routine:

- Morning: 1–2 minutes of open attention. Feel the 4 centers.
- Midday: 1–2 minutes of reconnecting.
- Evening: relaxing, and observing the space.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: Did I remember to “open” my attention at those 3 moments?

★ Small reminders build a continuous state of presence.

Day 3 — Sky Gazing & Unification *Anywhere / outdoors · A few minutes*

When you look at the sky, your eyes naturally open into peripheral vision. Your body grounds itself, and the space allows your breath to release.

Exercise — Unification:

- Feel the body (gravity).
- Observe the breath.
- Focus the attention.
- Open into Space (sky gazing).

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: How does it feel when all 4 centers come together?

★ You are not only the body — you are also the space that surrounds it.

Day 4 — Our Daily Routine *Anywhere · A few minutes*

We consolidate the practice. Reading and practicing now means: Body, Breath, Space, Attention.

Sky gazing. Open attention morning, midday, and evening.

Exercise — Sky & the 4 Centers:

- We establish the habit: every morning, midday, evening.
- Awareness through all 4 centers at once.
- The sky is our inspiration for space.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: Does open attention come more easily now?

★ Attention doesn't need tightening. It needs opening.

Day 5 — The Momentary Pause *Anywhere · 2–5 seconds*

We enter the last 10 days of the program. Through these days, alongside the base practice (4 centers, sky gazing, open attention 3×/day), we'll use **micro-exercises lasting seconds**.

Exercise — The Momentary Pause (Short Moment):

- For 2–5 seconds, let your thoughts be exactly as they are.
- Don't try to change them; don't judge them.
- Simply rest inside those few seconds.
- Do this several times today.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: Can a 3-second pause really bring calm?

★ The pause is the doorway to the Now.

Day 6 — The “Open Horizon” *Anywhere · A few seconds*

We continue: body, breath, attention, space. Three times a day (morning, midday, evening), plus sky gazing.

Today's micro-exercise helps us stop clinging to thoughts. Contrary to what we believe, thoughts need our “closed” space in order to survive. When we open the mental field, thoughts dissolve on their own.

Exercise — The “Open Horizon”:

- Imagine that your mind is the boundless sky.
- Your thoughts are clouds passing through.
- Don't chase the clouds.

- Remain the sky.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: Did I manage not to follow a “cloud” (a thought) today?

★ You don’t have to clear the sky of clouds. The sky always has room.

Day 7 — Interrupting the Autopilot *During an activity · 3 seconds*

Morning, midday, evening: open attention and the 4 centers. The sky remains your teacher in the feeling of space.

Today we break the routine with small interruptions. The mind’s “autopilot” (the Default Mode Network from our very first day) feeds on ceaseless, breathless motion. When we cut it, the nervous system gets a “reset.”

Exercise — Interrupting the Autopilot:

- While doing something ordinary (washing your hands, say).
- Pause for 3 seconds.
- Simply feel that you “exist,” without thinking about the next step.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: How many times did I catch myself on “autopilot”?

★ The magic hides between the habitual motions.

Week 8 — Space / Water: The Infinite Cosmic Ocean (Tai Chi)

Day 1 — The Mind Is Not Broken (Mahamudra) *Anywhere · A few seconds*

We enter the final week. The kindness we’ve been practicing is not an attempt to “become good” — it is the clearing away of the “echoes” left by rejection.

In the philosophy of Mahamudra, the mind is not broken — it is like muddied water. When you stop trying to control it, the “mud” settles by itself. The gold — your natural, innate kindness — was there all along, beneath the storm.

Exercise — Making Room for Kindness:

- When you feel pressure or resistance, instead of “fighting” it...
- Simply accept the situation.
- Give it free room. Say: “Let it be exactly as it is.”
- Watch the “mud” settle without any effort of yours.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: Did I feel relief in understanding that I am not “damaged”?

★ Resisting the feeling stirs the water. Accepting it lets it clear.

Day 2 — The Six Words of Advice (Non-Striving) *Anywhere · A few seconds*

Today we practice Tilopa’s six pieces of advice — the heart of “non-striving,” which quiets the Mechanical Mind.

1. Don’t recall (the past).
2. Don’t imagine (the future).
3. Don’t think (the inner monologue).
4. Don’t examine (analysis).
5. Don’t control (effort).
6. Rest (let go).

Exercise — The Non-Striving Test:

- In a moment of rest:
- Don’t analyze whether you’re doing well or badly.
- Don’t even try to control your breath.
- Feel your axis, and simply “rest” in the Now.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: What is it like when the compulsion to control stops?

★ The mind doesn’t need rules to be at peace. It only needs to be let go.

Day 3 — The Elephant, the Monkey & the Lasso *Anywhere · A little while*

The ancient parable of the samatha practitioner meets neurophysiology! Your mind is a runaway black elephant (the nervous system), driven by a monkey (the DMN). Your lasso is the “gentle return” of awareness.

You don’t strike the elephant. You throw the lasso softly and bring him back. This quite literally builds the insula of your brain.

Exercise — The Modern Practitioner:

- Pause for a few seconds.
- Observe the present moment.
- When the “elephant” bolts toward anxiety, gently cast the lasso of awareness.
- Return to your soles and your breath. Congratulations — you just built neuroplasticity.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: Did the “gentle return” feel like a safe lasso, rather than a punishment?

★ Every return of attention is a muscle growing stronger.

Day 4 — The Silence Behind the Sounds *Anywhere (even in noise) · A few seconds*

Listen, and open into space (morning, midday, evening). Today’s micro-exercise uses hearing to find the gap — the openness.

Just as the practitioner feels the space beneath his tree, feel the space around you.

Exercise — The Silence Behind the Sounds:

- As you hear any sound...
- Try, at the same time, to notice the silence in the background.
- Feel the silence out of which the sound is born.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: Is the silence always there, behind the noise?

★ As the sky hosts the clouds, silence hosts the sounds.

Day 5 — The Space Inside the Body *Anywhere · A few seconds*

The 4 centers — Body, Breath, Attention, Space — become one. The immense sky guides us, and open attention becomes our own personal Mahamudra.

Exercise — The Space Inside the Body:

- Take a brief pause.
- Can you imagine your chest filled with empty space?
- Picture it as an empty, open vessel.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: How does the chest feel when it isn't compressed?

★ Spaciousness in the chest is the biological signature of peace.

Day 6 — Giving Space to Others *In your interactions · A few seconds*

The same “open space” of kindness we offer ourselves, we now learn to offer to the people around us.

We let them exist, unforced, within the space — with no attempt at control — exactly as we let our own “elephant” be.

Exercise — Spacious Kindness:

- In one of today's conversations...
- Feel your axis and your feet.
- Offer the other person an “empty space” of acceptance.
- Don't try to steer them. Simply let them be.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: How did the conversation change when I stopped pushing?

★ The best relationship is the one that lets both people breathe.

Day 7 — Completing the Journey Anywhere · Open-ended

The final day of the program. Reading and practicing now simply means: join the 4 centers. Look at the sky. Keep your attention open. And remember: your mind is not broken.

Exercise — Life as Sky / Effortless Presence:

- Open your eyes to the sky.
- Feel gravity in the body.
- Hear the silence behind the sounds.
- Feel that you yourself are this Open Horizon.

Breath: Breathing from the sky

Reflection: What do I carry with me from these 8 weeks?

★ We don't arrive anywhere. We simply remember how to be HERE.

7-Day Practice Journal

Each day, note what you practiced, how it felt, and what you noticed. It doesn't have to be perfect — it only has to be true.

Day 1 · Monday — Date: _____ ☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space What I noticed today:

Day 2 · Tuesday — Date: _____ ☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space What I noticed today:

Day 3 · Wednesday — Date: _____ ☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space What I noticed today:

Day 4 · Thursday — Date: _____ ☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space What I noticed today:

Day 5 · Friday — Date: _____ ☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space What I noticed today:

Day 6 · Saturday — Date: _____ ☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space What I noticed today:

Day 7 · Sunday — Date: _____ ☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space What I noticed today:

Appendix — The Rabbit Hole

The “Rabbit Hole” is a collection of optional, deeper texts inside the app — contemplative and scientific extensions of the method, for anyone who wants to go further. All of it is free. Below, organized by chapter.

Body (Ch. 1)

- **The Veils of Being** — the matryoshka allegory: five veils, from the physical body to pure consciousness.

Breath (Ch. 2)

- **Learning to Ride the Wind** — the breath as a wind you accompany, not one you control.
- **The Lute String and the Vagus Nerve** — polyvagal theory and the nervous system’s middle way (also relevant to Ch. 7).

Attention (Ch. 3)

- **The Soft Gaze: A Door That Doesn’t Lock** — how peripheral vision and open hearing regulate the nervous system.

Space (Ch. 4)

- **The Wave Is Not the Sea — Until It Lets Go** — the distinction between mindfulness ($\triangle$) and awareness (∞).
- **You Are the Path: The Map, the Territory & the Axis** — map and territory, and entering the now through the axis.
- **The Seething Void** — the quantum vacuum and awareness.

The Neurodivergent Mind (Ch. 5)

- **The Truth Behind the Labels: Plato’s Cave** — the allegory of the cave through the lens of neurodivergence.
- **The Goose Is Out** — the goose koan, and masking.
- **Never by Force** — why pushing in practice backfires; the art of the effortless return (the thread of kindness).

Stages & Tradition (Ch. 9–10)

- **Dzogchen: The Great Perfection** — an introduction to effortless awareness.
- **The Nature of Mind & the Release of Tension** — the nature of mind, Trekchö, and neuroscience.
- **The Forces of the Cosmos, the Axes of the Mind** — the elements/forces and the four axes.

About the app itself

- **What Does “Sandbox” Mean?** — the idea of a “safe space to practice.”

Epilogue

This path has no ending. It is a way of standing within your life — consciously choosing acceptance at every step.

Any moment can become a small return to gentleness and openness.

Mindfulness, in the end, is remembering that there is already an open space inside you — one that holds you exactly as you are.

That space asks nothing and rejects nothing. It simply reminds you that you are present, alive, and whole.